



Fastest SSDs on earth

Pliant technologies, a little known manufacturer Drops Bombshell "Lightning" SSD With 180k IOPS, 500/320 MB/s Read/Writes



Targeting the no-man's land between netbooks and notebooks the AMD Neo CPU along with ATI graphics allows for a powerful solution with a very slim and compact footprint

Laptop test



free. The keypad is well designed and the keys are excellently spaced. A small fingerprint scanner is provided on the right side of the palmrest to allow biometrics-based login. The tested battery life is good – just over four hours – enough to keep you productive over most domestic flights. Priced at Rs. 99,000 plus tax the EliteBook 2530P is expensive, but those who appreciate its subtle talents will shell out.

The Sony Vaio SR46GD is Sony's answer to the businessman wanting something on a shoestring, if Rs. 74,900 can be considered a shoestring. However, this is as low as they corporate series of notebooks is likely to be priced. The SR46GD is heavier than its sibling and the entire body is made of some fibre-based compound that isn't rigid. It's a good-looking notebook based on the attractive cylindrical design (Sony speak for the circular section connecting the base and the lid). The keys are not well designed at all and the gap between keys is too much and the keys themselves too small. In fact this is one of the worst designed keypads we've come across. Obviously if you

use it long enough you will get accustomed to it; but the two days over which we used this notebook had us running for cover. There are five usability modes activated via five shortcut keys. These usability modes change the operating environment according to your needs and the application shortcuts available in each mode can be configured.

The Core 2 Duo P8700 and Radeon HD 4570 are both pretty powerful solutions. The Wi-Fi switch is very conveniently located and the activity indicators on the notebook are optimally positioned – Sony has their ergonomics spot on. The trackpad is accurate but there is slight lag, however the tracking surface is well designed and doesn't slip or grip too much. If its features appeal to you and you cannot spend any more than 74,900 this is a decent buy and certainly looks a little more upmarket than the HP 4410S, understandable really since it costs nearly double.

If you are looking for something really classy however, and don't mind shelling out big (really big!) then check out the Sony Vaio

VGN-Z48GD – the echelon of upwardly mobile in Sony's books. Their 'Z' series are hardcore business notebooks – sleek, feature-rich and expensive. The Z48GD has 256 GB worth of SSD under the hood. And that's not all, further inspection revealed two SSD drives of 128 GB each configured in RAID 0. We figure these drives themselves would cost Rs. 50,000 if not more. On the outside the Z48GD is ultra slim and really light. The display used is a WLED and the lid is very slim as a result. Since it looks much smaller than the HP 4410S we were surprised to see it had a display as large as 13.1-inches. The body is built of carbon fibre – rugged although there is noticeable flex. We're told this is normal and doesn't affect durability in the least. Even the lid seems flexible and we were initially concerned about its flex leading to damage of the display. Sony reassured us that this sort of flex is intentional as using hard material for the lid cover would actually risk cracking of the LED-based LCD inside. This is because LED-backlit LCDs are apparently much slimmer than regular LCDs and therefore prone to damage i.e. cracking. But wouldn't flexing the lid also lead to cracking of the display inside? Oh well, we couldn't get answers for everything. The famous Sony *Stamina Mode* is present and can be used at the flick of a toggle switch. This allows shifting between stamina and performance modes which internally switches between Intel integrated graphics and NVIDIAs GeForce 9300M giving you either extended battery life or more video performance. Unlike its earlier avatars that required a Windows restart this version of Stamina Mode makes do with just shutting down all running applications and switching modes causes your screen to blank out momentarily as the graphics adapter changes. Sadly the keypad is still a pain to work with thanks to tiny, ill

spaced keys. The trackpad is also small and a little cramped but tracking is good. Still you will want to invest in a wireless mouse to get the best out of this notebook.

In terms of performance this notebooks storage subsystem blows everything else away, as expected with the striped SSD drives. It also has a very powerful 2.8 GHz Core 2 Duo (P9700) processor and this, coupled with 6 GB of RAM and a 64-bit OS (necessary to address more than 4 GB of RAM) makes the Z48GD a potent performer in a diminutive package. A real pocket rocket, and priced likewise too – Rs. 1,49,900 is not cheap; but then this level of pedigree rarely is. It's our *Best Performer* award winner on account of its superb all round performance.

Sony Vaio VGN-Z48GD



ULTRA COMPACT LAPTOPS:
He ain't heavy, he's my ultra compact!

By definition an ultra compact notebook is one that is lightweight and small. This necessitates a small screen size; not more than 13.3-inches. Anything smaller than 11.1-inches and it becomes a netbook. Of course an ultra compact notebook can also be a business notebook, since the very term ultra compact is generic and doesn't specify suitability to a particular